



Antidote

Profitability review and Fluke case study

Small, certain, fast.

35 sales · \$12,169 in · \$4,120 profit · funded out of pocket

Camilo · Antidote LLC

Buy fewer units. Buy bigger ones.

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Part one: profitability review

A \$1,000 meter earns the same 40% as a \$200 meter and sells just as fast. Hours limit this business. Money does not.

80%

of profit came from meters I bought

41.8%

return on money I put into Fluke

1.9 days

from buying a Fluke to selling it

74%

of my profit is Fluke alone

What I found

- Free finds made 60% of my summer profit. They make 20% now.
- The return holds near 40% from a \$110 meter to a \$1,000 one.
- I look up the price before I buy. Meters sell in two days.

What I should do

- Put the money into Fluke.
- Raise what I pay per meter. Same hours, bigger sale.
- Test every meter before paying above a ceiling.

One product line makes three quarters of the profit

Where the money comes from

Free finds carried the summer. A jacket, a weight set, old phones. They cost nothing, so all of it was profit.

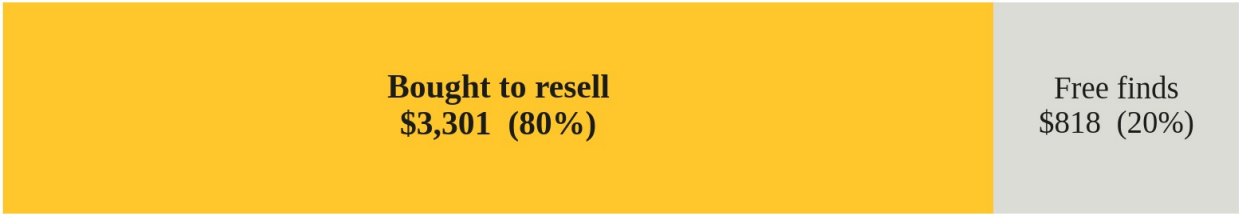
They make 20% now. Fluke is \$3,056 of the \$4,120 I have made, across nineteen sales.

That is the business. Everything else is noise.

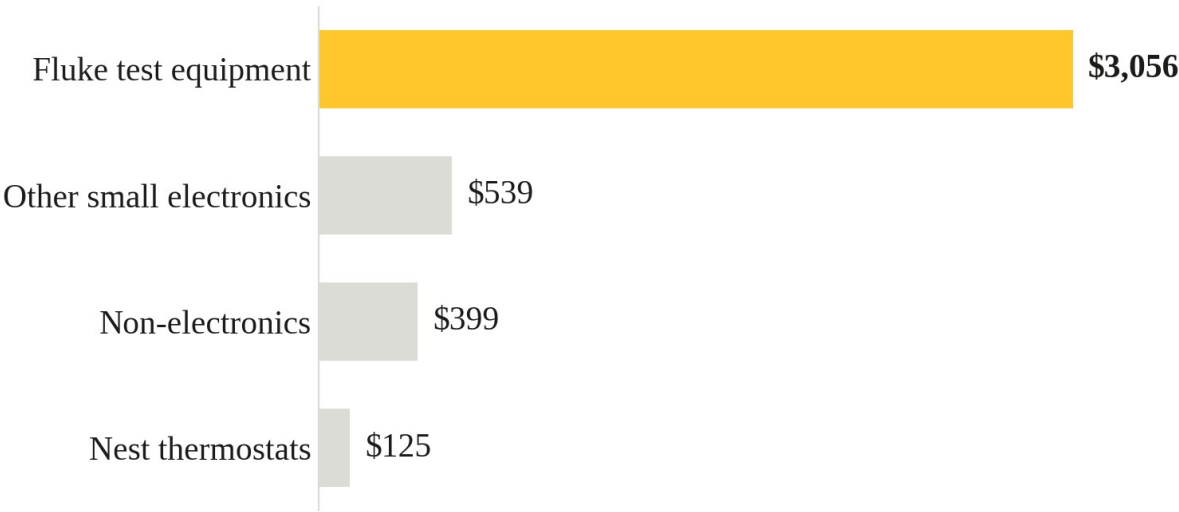
About that margin

My blended margin fell from 48% to 34%. Free items cost nothing, so they book at 100% and flatter the average. As the bought side grew, they stopped carrying it. Margin on what I buy held near 30%.

Profit by how I got the item



Profit by product line

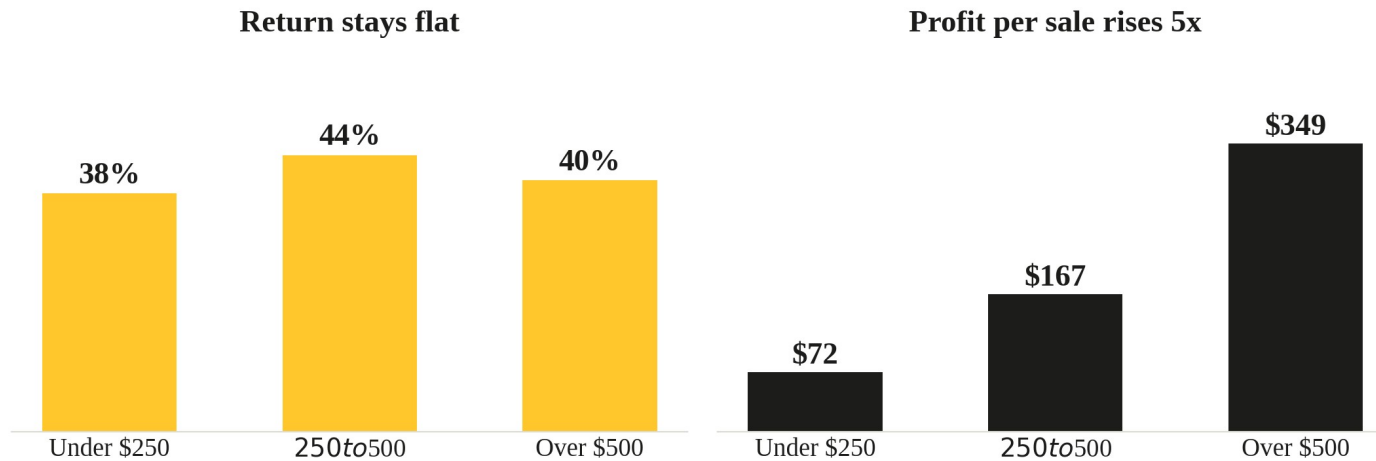


35 sold units. Free finds cost me nothing to acquire. Percentages are of profit, not sales.

A \$1,000 meter earns the same rate as a \$200 one

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Does this break if it gets bigger?



I sorted all nineteen Fluke sales by what I paid.

The return barely moves: 38%, then 44%, then 40%.
Hold time sits near two days in every group.

Profit per sale moves a lot. \$72, then \$167, then \$349.

Every sale costs me the same search.

Why this settles the strategy

Finding a \$1,000 meter takes no longer than finding a \$200 one. My ceiling is hours, not cash: at a two-day hold I only need enough money for one meter at a time. When every sale costs the same search, raise the price of the meter.

Against the research

Work on AI-run retail arbitrage warns those margins may be “not sustainable when the scale... is significantly increased” (Tanlamai et al., 2024). Mine held across a 10x range. Their model buys and sells in one market, so rivals close the gap. I buy on Marketplace and sell on eBay.

Cash that comes back in two days

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Speed, and the one buy that did not have it

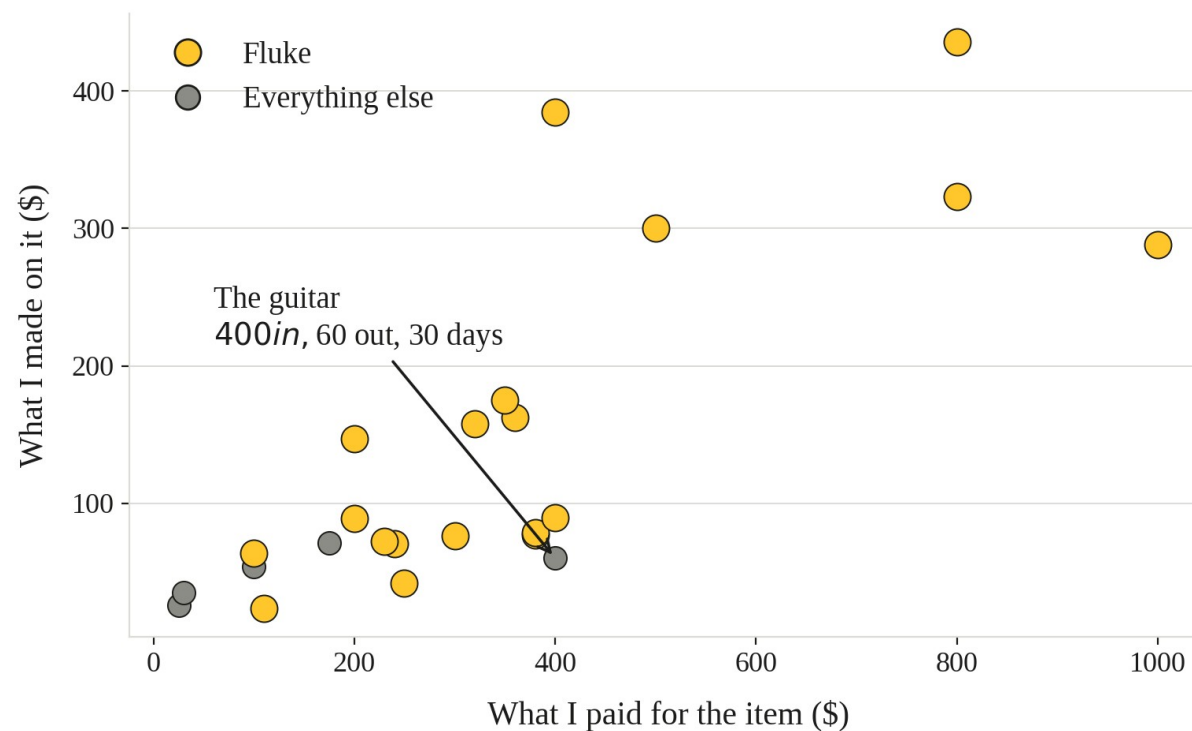
Retail research finds that “inventory turnover is negatively correlated with demand uncertainty” (Hançerlioğulları et al., 2016). Stock sits when you cannot tell what it is worth. That research also describes a trade most sellers accept: higher margin costs you speed.

Fluke pays me both. My highest margin at 29.5%, my fastest sale at 1.9 days. I do not guess what an 87V goes for. I look it up, then buy under it.

The one that did not work

One guitar. I paid \$400 and made \$60. The 15% is not the problem. It held my cash 30 days while everything else turned in three.

I never lost a dollar. The dollars could not move. That \$400 in a Fluke pays about \$167 and comes back in two days.



Meters that fit the rules cluster tight and come back fast. The guitar sits alone: the most cash I ever committed, near the least I ever made.

Raise the ticket. Keep the rules.

Part one: what I am going to do

- 1. Put the money into Fluke.** 74% of profit, a 41.8% return, nineteen sales behind it.
- 2. Raise what I pay per meter.** The return holds to \$1,000. Profit per sale does not.
- 3. Test before paying above a ceiling.** A dead \$1,000 meter is a real loss. The guitar was only slow.
- 4. Skip anything large, slow, or optional.** Those buys break the speed this runs on.

If I keep finding three meters a month

I pay	Cash needed	Profit a month
\$250	\$750	about \$313
\$500	\$1,500	about \$627
\$800	\$2,400	about \$1,003

Same hours. Same two days. A bigger meter.

What could go wrong

I have not tracked my search hours, so the table rests on my own estimate.

Only three sales sit above \$500. That 40% needs more meters behind it.

All of this runs through one brand and one place to buy. If Marketplace dries up or used Fluke prices fall, most of my profit goes with it.

Part two

The Fluke case study

Should I put more hours and more money into one product line?

Fluke sells trust. I resell it.

The company's strategy, and my use of it

A multimeter is safety equipment. Read a live wire as dead and someone gets hurt. Fluke built its position on that fact: compete on trust and longevity, never on price. A deliberate strategy, not an accident of engineering.

“Budget meters often fail within 2-5 years” (Revine, 2025). A Fluke runs fifteen to twenty-five, and *“many electricians are still using Fluke meters from the 1990s”* (SparkShift, 2026).

A product built to refuse to wear out is why a ten-year-old unit still sells for real money. Their strategy is my margin: in the used market, a Fluke competes only with other Flukes.

What this means for me

The buyer cannot test a used meter before it ships. The Fluke name does the testing for him.

So I buy from a Marketplace seller who wants it gone, and sell to an electrician who needs a meter he can trust on Monday.

No other meter brand carries trust across a resale. That is the entire niche.

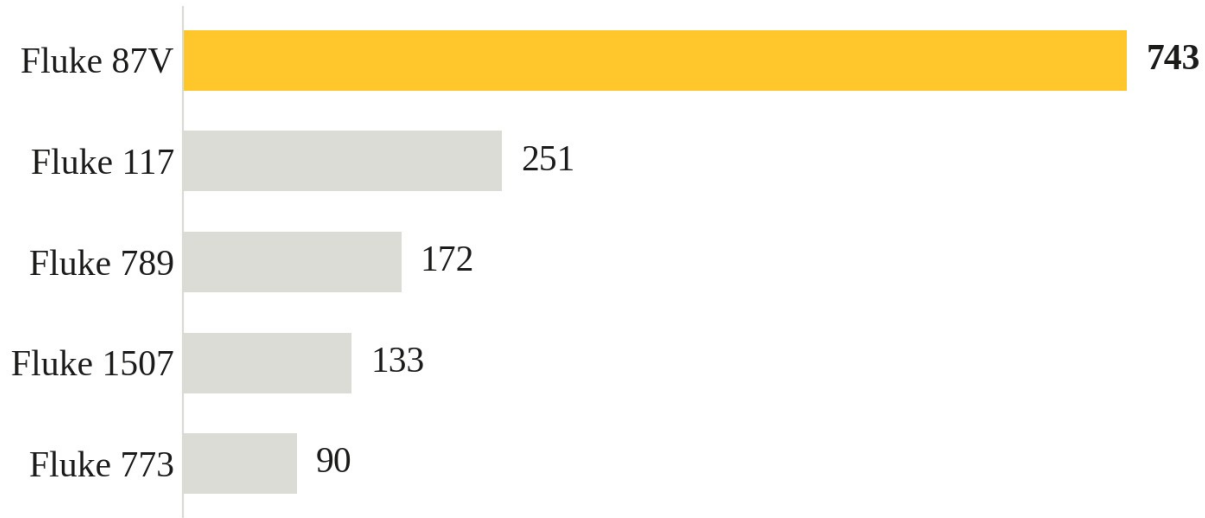
Where I would push back on myself

Fluke is not a monopoly. Klein sells credible meters at lower prices and many electricians carry both. Fluke owns the premium and industrial end, which is the end that holds its value.

Demand is not what limits me. I am 1% of it.

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How big is this market?



Recent sold listings on eBay, five models I actually trade

Those five models cleared 1,389 recent sales on eBay. I have sold nineteen Fluke units in total, across more models than these five.

Even if every one of my sales landed inside that same window, I would be 1.4% of it.

I could sell ten times what I sell today and still not press against this market.

Read this carefully

eBay reports these as recently ended, not as a fixed window, so 1,389 is a floor on demand and 1.4% is a ceiling on my share. Both point the same way: buyers are not my problem.

My hours are what limit me

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So what would more hours buy?

3 hrs

a week searching Marketplace today

1 meter

found every one to two weeks

I pass on listings I can see, because I run out of time before I run out of meters. That makes this a time problem, not a money problem or a demand problem.

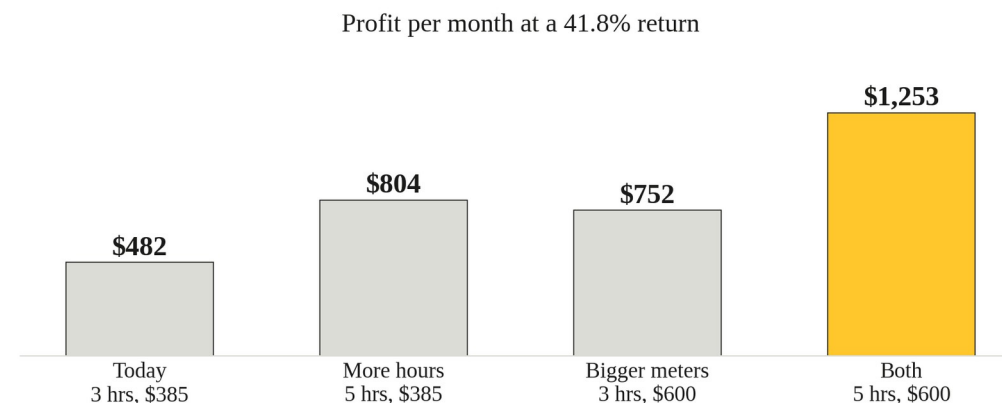
Going from three hours to five is a 1.7x increase. If finding meters scales with looking for them, that is roughly five meters a month instead of three.

The assumption doing the work

More hours means proportionally more meters. I have not tested that. If good listings are rarer than my time is short, the fifth hour finds less than the first.

5 hrs

the most I would realistically spend



Two levers: hours and ticket. Both together beat either alone.

Go to five hours. Buy bigger meters.

Part two: the call

Scale it. Demand is 1,389 recent sales and I am 1.4% of it. The return holds at 40% to \$1,000 a unit. Nothing about this niche is close to full.

Both levers, not one. Five hours a week at a \$600 average ticket takes me from about \$482 a month to about \$1,253. Hours alone get \$804. Ticket alone gets \$752.

Fund it with \$3,000. Five meters a month at \$600. At a two-day hold the cash turns over fast enough that I never hold all five at once.

Track the hours starting now. Every number above rests on a find rate I have never measured.

Profit a month, at a 41.8% return

Hours	Ticket	Profit
3 hrs	\$385	\$482
5 hrs	\$385	\$804
3 hrs	\$600	\$752
5 hrs	\$600	\$1,253

What kills this

A dead meter. Condition risk scales with the ticket, so the test rule matters more at \$1,000 than it did at \$200.

Other resellers finding the same gap on Marketplace.

My own time. Five hours is a ceiling I set in a summer, not a semester.